

Sydney funnelweb spider

Atrax robustus



This funnelweb is a member of the mygalomorph spider group, whose prominent fangs point straight down rather than diagonally as in other spiders. It spins its tube-shaped web in a cool, moist, shady site, under a rock or log—or an outhouse. Repeated bites quickly subdue its small prey; untreated, the venom may be fatal to humans.

In late summer, the smaller, longer-legged, wider-roaming male mates with the more sedentary female. She keeps the 100–150 eggs in a silken egg sac safe in her burrow. They hatch in three to four weeks and the spiderlings remain for a few more months.

▷ GOOD VIBRATIONS

Silk thread trip lines fan out from the web entrance and alert the funnelweb spider to passing prey.



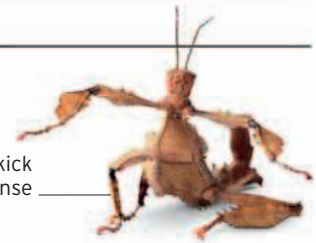
- ↔ 1–2 in (2.5–5 cm)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🕸 Insects, snails, frogs, mice
- 🏠 🌳 🌿



Macleay's specter

Extatosoma tiaratum

spiny legs kick in defense



Also known as the giant prickly stick insect, Macleay's specter is well camouflaged by the twigs of its favorite food trees: eucalyptus. Females are longer, twice as heavy, and spinier than males, and their small wing buds mean they cannot fly. The slimmer, winged males fly readily, especially to find a mate. The female flicks her abdomen when releasing her eggs so they reach the forest floor. The eggs are gathered by spider ants, which carry them to their colony, then eat the outer layer but leave the rest of the egg intact. Hatching nymphs mimic the colors of their hosts, protecting them until they leave the colony in search of food trees.



◁ GREEN LICHEN FORM

Among the colored forms of this species, *E. t. tiaratum* is hard to spot amid green leaves, lichens, and mosses.

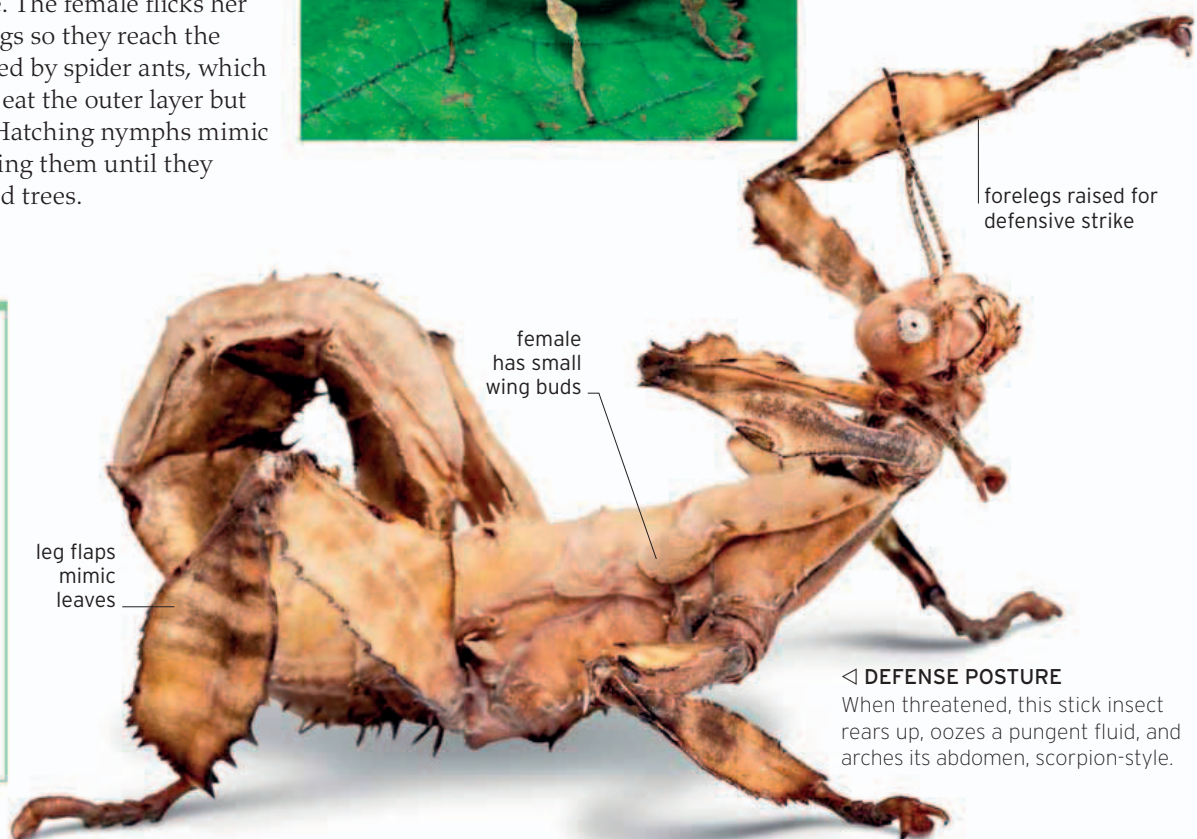
forelegs raised for defensive strike

- ↔ 3–7 in (7.6–18 cm)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🕸 Leaves, especially eucalyptus
- 🏠 🌳 🌿



leg flaps mimic leaves

female has small wing buds



◁ DEFENSE POSTURE

When threatened, this stick insect rears up, oozes a pungent fluid, and arches its abdomen, scorpion-style.